

# Education Indicator

## EDUCATION AND LEARNING OUTCOMES

## School leavers with Vocational Pathways Award

In 2024, 12% of school leavers achieved a Vocational Pathways Award. This was an increase of 0.5 percentage points from 2023 and a decrease of 16.9 percentage points since 2014.

### Indicator description

Percentage of school leavers who achieved at least one of the Vocational Pathways Awards.

### Why Vocational Pathways are important

Vocational Pathways were developed to help students see how their learning is valued in the real world by aligning standards that can be achieved through NCEA within six industries. Vocational Pathways ensure students gain a better understanding of how their NCEA studies apply to the world of work, and the qualifications and skills required by industry. Achieving a Vocational Pathways Award means that students have achieved NCEA Level 2 standards that align with the knowledge and skills that employers are looking for in one of the six industries:

- Primary Industries (PI)
- Manufacturing & Technology (MT)
- Services Industries (SI)
- Creative Industries (CI)
- Social & Community Services (SCS)
- Construction & Infrastructure (C&I)

All standards included in a particular Vocational Pathways Award are recommended, and a subset of these recommended standards are identified as sector related. Recommended standards support a strong foundational curriculum, and sector-related standards are directly relevant to employment contexts.

To achieve a Vocational Pathways Award, a student must achieve NCEA Level 2 which includes literacy (10 credits) and numeracy (10 credits) at Level 1 or above and 60 NCEA Level 2 credits from the recommended Assessment Standards for Vocational Pathways, including 20 Level 2 credits from sector-related standards.

Developing and strengthening both general and vocational education at upper secondary level can make education more inclusive and appealing to individuals with different preferences and aptitudes. Vocational education is an attractive option for youth who are more interested in practical occupations and for those who want to enter the labour market earlier. Vocational education supports youth to reintegrate into a learning environment and develop skills that will increase their employability. It can also serve as a route into higher level studies OECD (2022).

## How are we going

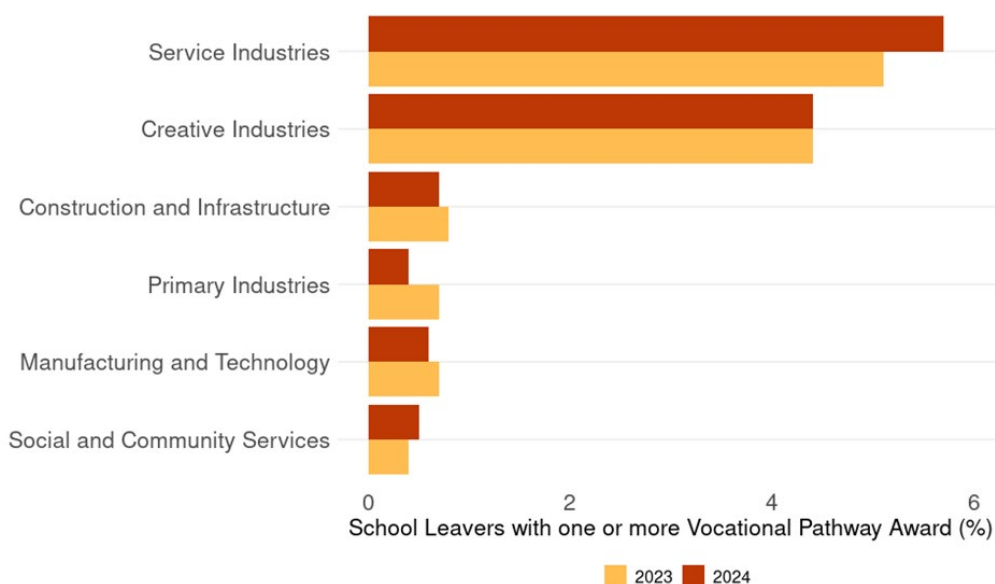
In 2024, 11.8% (7,956) of school leavers attained NCEA Level 2 with any Vocational Pathways Award, a 0.5 percentage point increase from 2023 school leavers (11.3%). Attainment of NCEA Level 2 with any Vocational Pathways Award peaked in 2017 at 34.7% and has dropped by 22.9 percentage points since then.

The overall trend for school leavers attaining any Vocational Pathways Award has been mixed over the years, changing from 19.3 in 2019 to 17.5 in 2020, 11.3 in 2023 and 11.8 in 2024.

Decisions made with industry in 2018 to refine the Vocational Pathways criteria from 2020 caused a drop in the number of senior students attaining a Vocational Pathways Award (from 18,647 school leavers with any Vocational Pathways Award in 2018 to 11,537 school leavers with any Vocational Pathways Award in 2019). This equates to a decrease of 11.3 percentage points. The full impact of the change in criteria for the Vocational Pathways Award was not seen until 2022, as students leaving school in 2019 and 2020 may have attained a Vocational Pathways Award under the old or new criteria, since it is usually completed in Year 12.

Figure 1 shows the attainment of Vocational Pathways Awards by Vocational Pathways industry. In 2024, 5.7% of school leavers achieved a Service Industries award, 4.4% achieved a Creative Industries award, 0.7% achieved a Construction and Infrastructure award, 0.6% achieved a Manufacturing and Technology award, 0.5% achieved a Social and Community Services award, and 0.4% achieved a Primary Industries award.

**Figure 1: Vocational Pathways Award is most often achieved by completing the industry standards for Service Industries and Creative Industries**



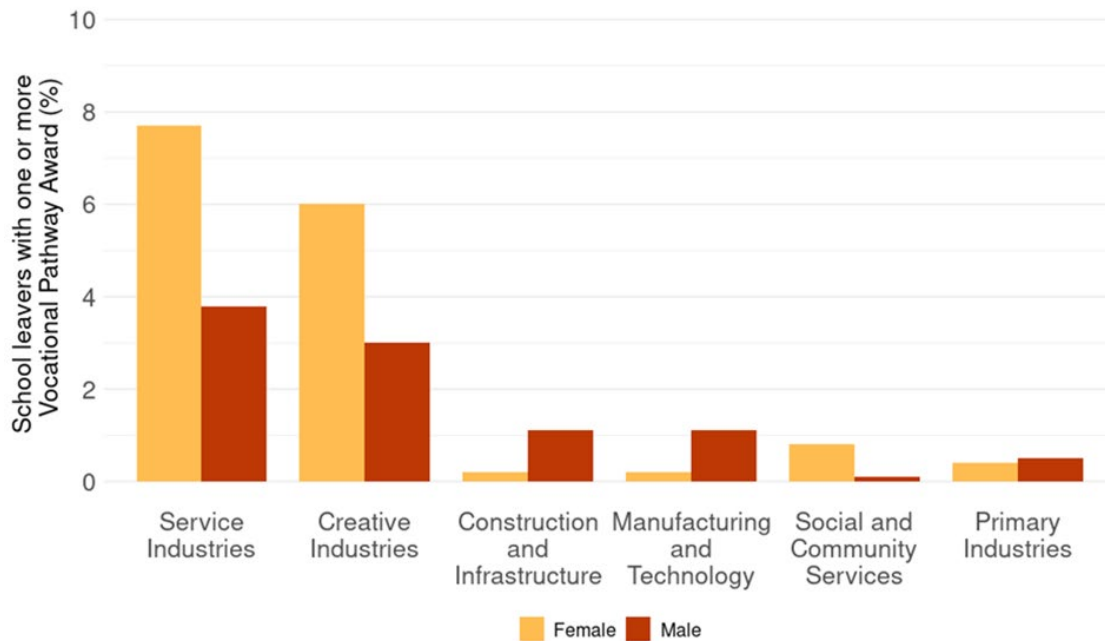
## Gender

Female school leavers were more likely to attain a Vocational Pathways Award than male school leavers. In 2024, 14.7% of female school leavers achieved at least one Vocational Pathways Award. This was 5.7 percentage points higher than male school leavers (9.0%).

Across all Vocational Pathways industries there were distinct gender differences in the proportion of leavers attaining the award (see Figure 2). Of the total school leavers in 2024, a higher proportion of females than males attained a Vocational Pathways Award in Service Industries (7.7% compared to 3.8%), Creative Industries (6% compared to 3%) and Social and Community Services (0.8% compared to 0.1%).

A higher proportion of males than females attained a Vocational Pathways Award in Primary Industries (0.5% compared to 0.4%), Manufacturing and Technology (1.1% compared to 0.2%) and Construction and Infrastructure (1.1% compared to 0.2%).

**Figure 2: Distinct gender differences were seen in the proportion of school leavers attaining Vocational Pathways Awards in 2024**



## Socioeconomic barriers<sup>1</sup>

At a system level, schools where students experience more socioeconomic barriers to achievement have lower NCEA Level 2 or above attainment rates and a higher variability of attainment rates within the School Equity Index Bands.

Figure 3 shows there was an association between the attainment of any Vocational Pathways Award and socioeconomic background. Schools where students had more socioeconomic barriers to achievement had lower proportions of school leavers with any Vocational Pathways Award, while those with fewer barriers had higher attainment rates.

**Figure 3: The percentage of school leavers with any Vocational Pathways Award varied amongst schools within each Equity Index Band.**

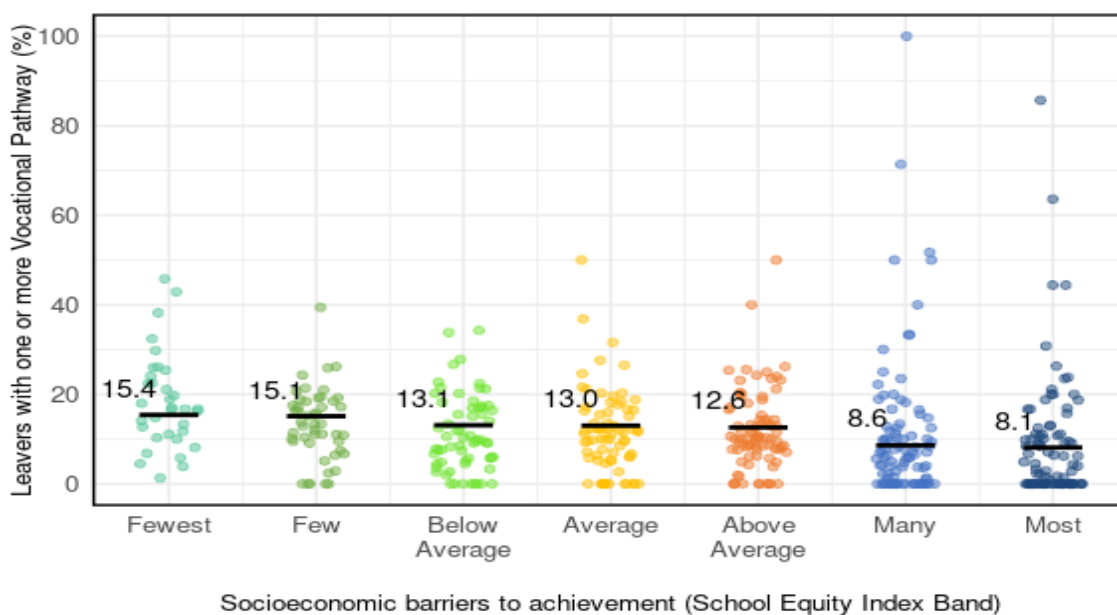


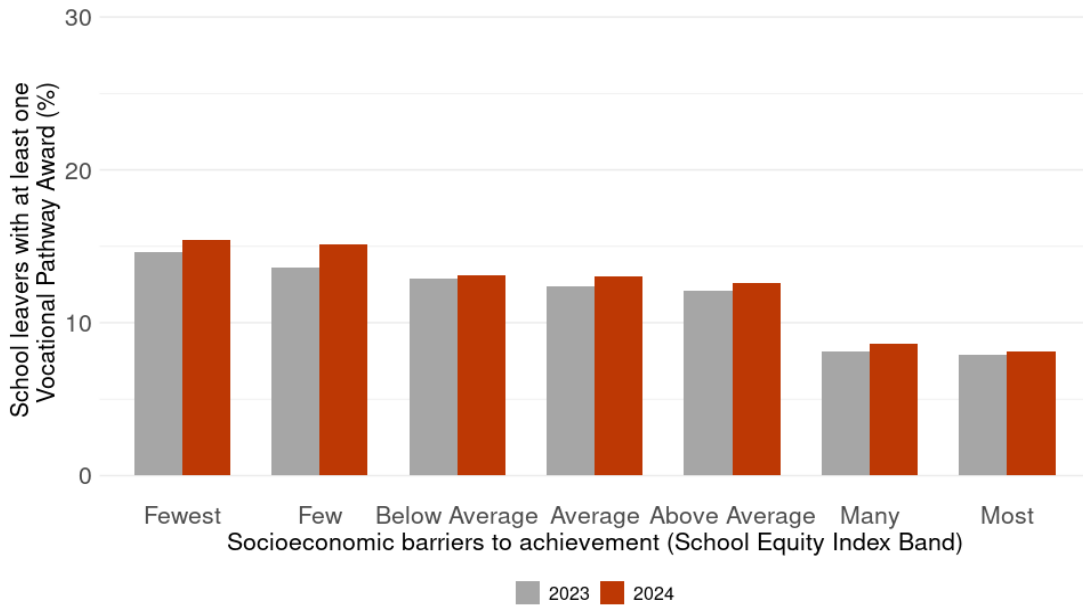
Figure 4 shows that in 2024, schools where students had the fewest barriers to achievement had 15.4% of school leavers attain any Vocational Pathways Award, and those with the most barriers to achievement had an attainment rate of 8.1%. Compared to 2023, the proportion of school leavers attaining a Vocational Pathways Award increased the most in schools where students had few barriers to achievement (from 13.6% in 2023 to 15.1% in 2024).

In schools where students had many barriers to achievement, the proportion of school leavers who attained any Vocational Pathways Award increased from 8.1% in 2023 to 8.6% in 2024. The proportion of school leavers attaining any Vocational Pathways Award from schools where students had the most barriers to achievement increased from 7.9% in 2023 to 8.1% in 2024.

<sup>1</sup> For more information about the equity index see the section at the end of this indicator report.



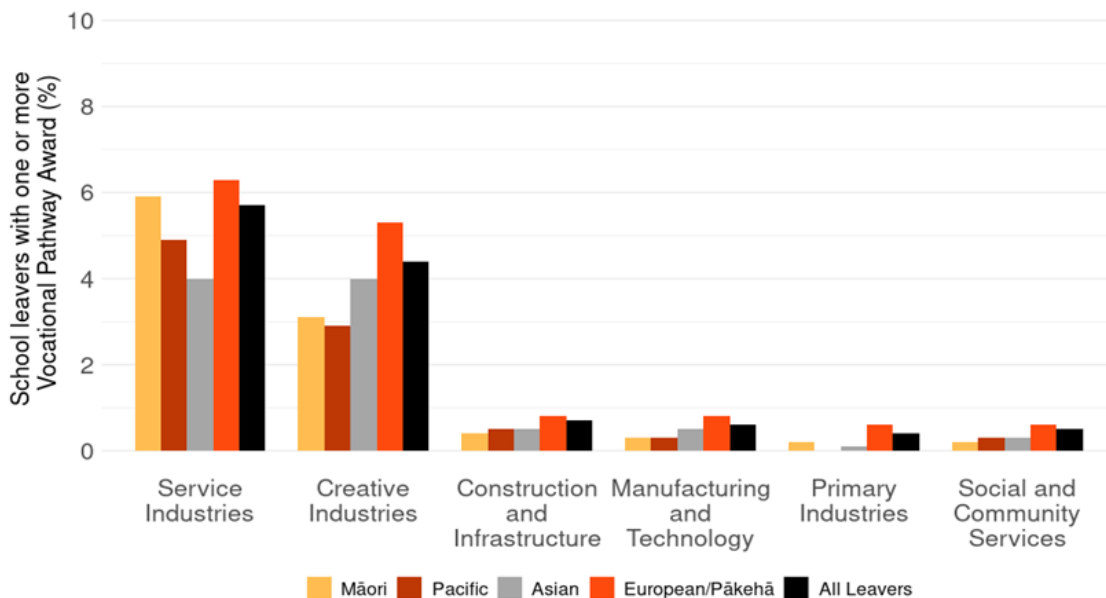
**Figure 4: The proportion of school leavers attaining a Vocational Pathways Award increased in 2024 compared to 2023**



## Ethnicity<sup>2</sup>

Service Industries and Creative Industries were the most common award types within each ethnic group.

**Figure 5: Service Industries and Creative Industries were the most common Vocational Pathways Award attained for all ethnic groups in 2024**



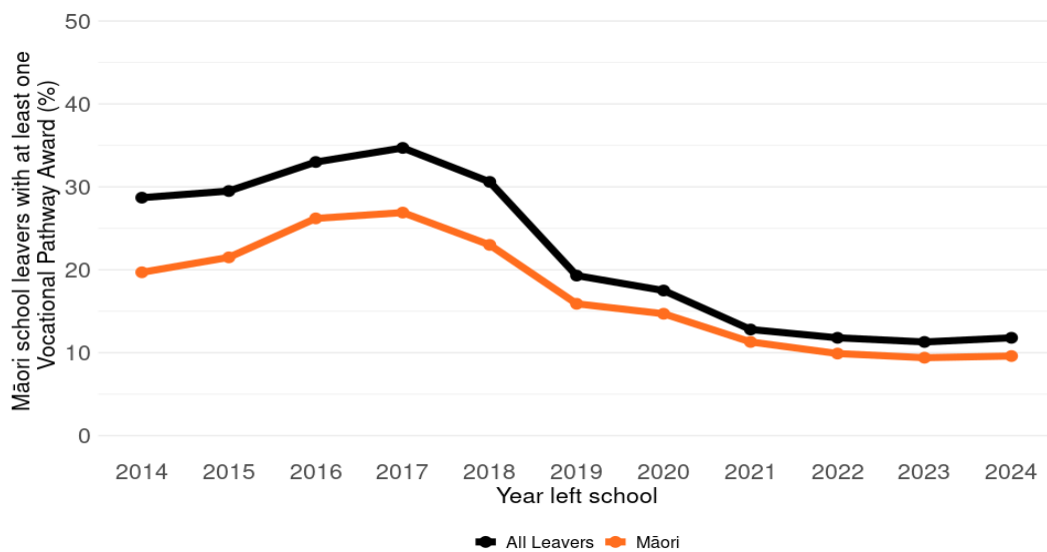
<sup>2</sup> Total response ethnicity counts school leavers who identify with more than one ethnic group in each of these ethnic groups. For the New Zealand total, individuals are counted only once.



## Ākonga Māori

In 2024, 1,611 Māori school leavers (9.6%) attained NCEA Level 2 with any Vocational Pathways Award, as shown in Figure 6. This was 0.2 percentage points up from 2023. Between 2017 (peak attainment for ākonga Māori) and 2024, the attainment of any Vocational Pathways Award decreased by 17.3 percentage points. Between 2020 (the first year of Covid-19) and 2024, the attainment rate decreased by 5.1 percentage points. The gap in the attainment of any Vocational Pathways Award between Māori school leavers and all school leavers in 2024 was 2.2 percentage points, up from 1.9 percentage points in 2023.

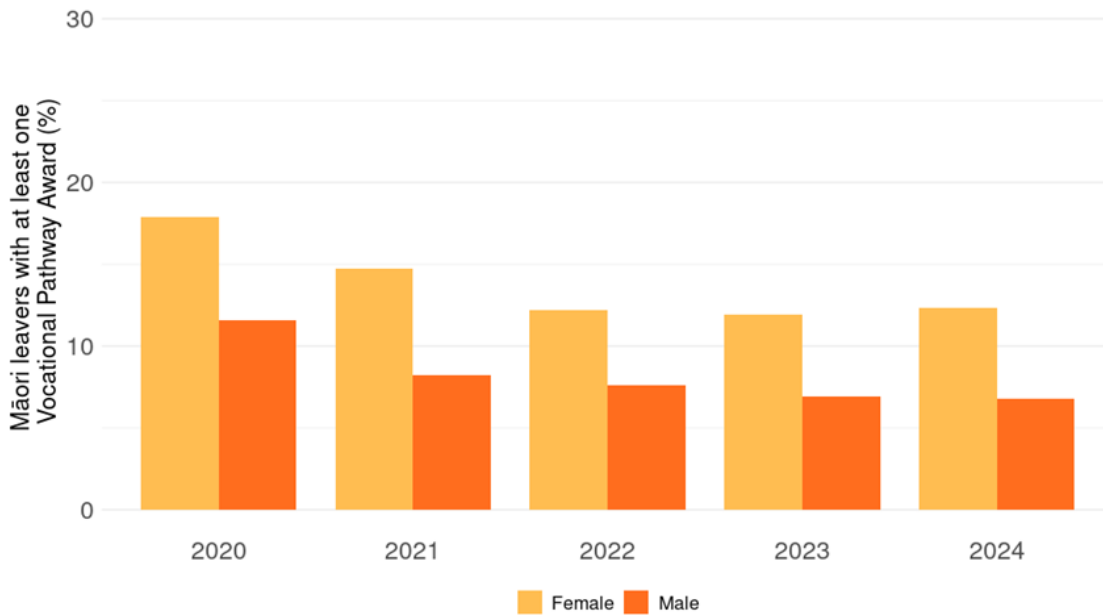
**Figure 6: Māori school leavers who attained NCEA Level 2 or above with any Vocational Pathways Award increased in 2024**



Since 2020, Māori female school leavers' attainment of any Vocational Pathways Award decreased from 17.9% to 12.3% in 2024, while the Māori male attainment rate decreased from 11.6% in 2020 to 6.8% in 2024.

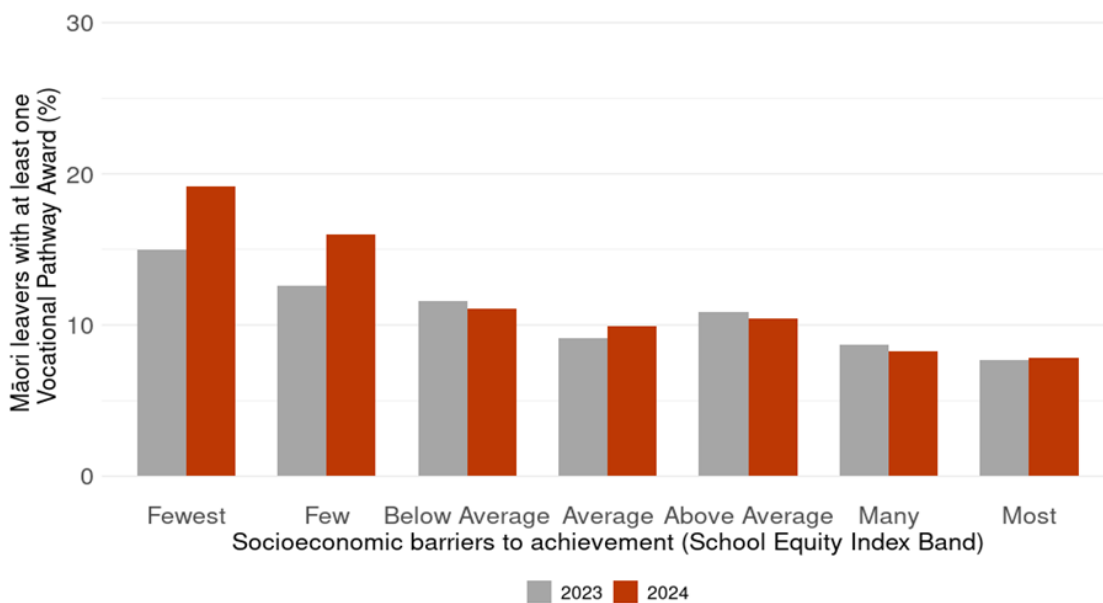


**Figure 7: Māori female school leavers were more likely to attain NCEA Level 2 or above with any Vocational Pathways Award**



Māori school leavers from schools where students had fewer barriers to achievement were more likely to attain NCEA Level 2 or above with any Vocational Pathways Award. In 2024, 19.2% of Māori leavers from schools where students had the fewest barriers to achievement attained any Vocational Pathways Award compared to 7.8% of Māori leavers from schools where students had the most barriers to achievement.

**Figure 8: Proportion of Māori school leavers who attained NCEA Level 2 or above with any Vocational Pathways Award by School Equity Index Bands**



## Māori and language of learning<sup>3</sup>

### Māori predominantly learning in te reo Māori

Of the 16,861 ākonga Māori who left school in 2024, 5% (835 Māori school leavers) were predominantly learning in te reo Māori. The number of Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in te reo Māori has increased 74.7% since 2014 (478 Māori school leavers in 2014).

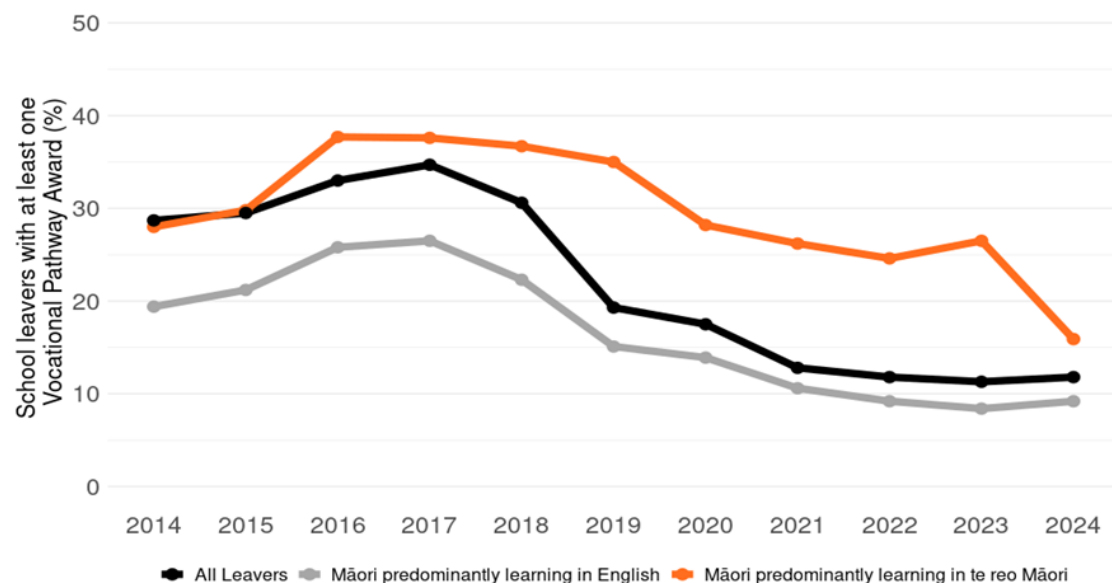
Note, that when looking at statistics based on small populations such as the small number of school leavers learning in te reo Māori, a small change in numbers can result in a relatively large change in proportions and therefore relatively large fluctuations from year to year.

In 2024, 15.9% of Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in te reo Māori when they left school attained NCEA Level 2 with any Vocational Pathways Award. This was a decrease of 10.6 percentage points from 2023, 12.1 percentage points from 2014 and 12.3 percentage points in 2020. Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in te reo Māori were more likely to attain a Vocational Pathways Award in Service Industries (13.2%) and Creative Industries (4.7%), compared to Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in English (5.5% and 3% respectively).

### Māori predominantly learning in English

Of the 16,861 Māori students who left school in 2024, 95% (16,026 Māori school leavers) were predominantly learning in English. In 2024, 9.2% of Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in English achieved NCEA Level 2 with any Vocational Pathways Award. This was an increase of 0.8 percentage points from 2023, and a decrease of 4.7 percentage points from 2020, and 10.2 percentage points since 2014.

**Figure 9: Māori school leavers who were predominantly learning in te reo Māori were more likely to attain a Vocational Pathways Award**



<sup>3</sup> The predominant language of learning is the one that school leavers are learning in at least 51% of the time.

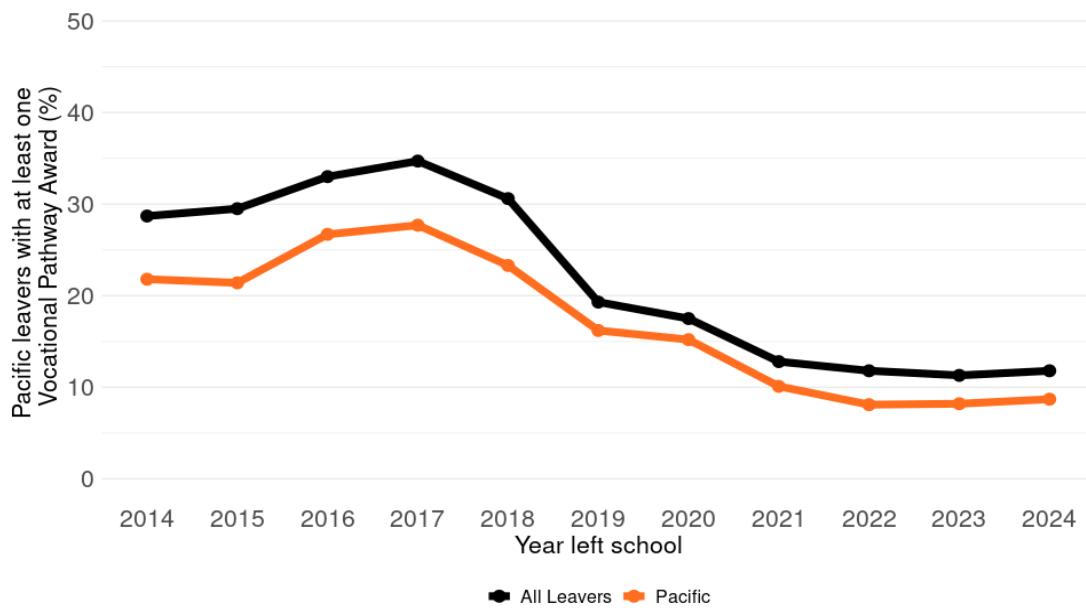




## Pacific school leavers

In 2024, 751 Pacific school leavers (8.7%) attained NCEA Level 2 with any Vocational Pathways Award, as shown in Figure 10. This was up 0.5 percentage points from 2023. Between 2017 (peak attainment for Pacific learners) and 2024, Pacific school leavers' attainment of any Vocational Pathways Award decreased by 19 percentage points. Between 2020 (the first year of Covid-19) and 2024, the attainment rate decreased by 6.5 percentage points. The gap in the attainment of any Vocational Pathways Award between Pacific school leavers and all school leavers in 2024 was 3.1 percentage points, unchanged from 2023.

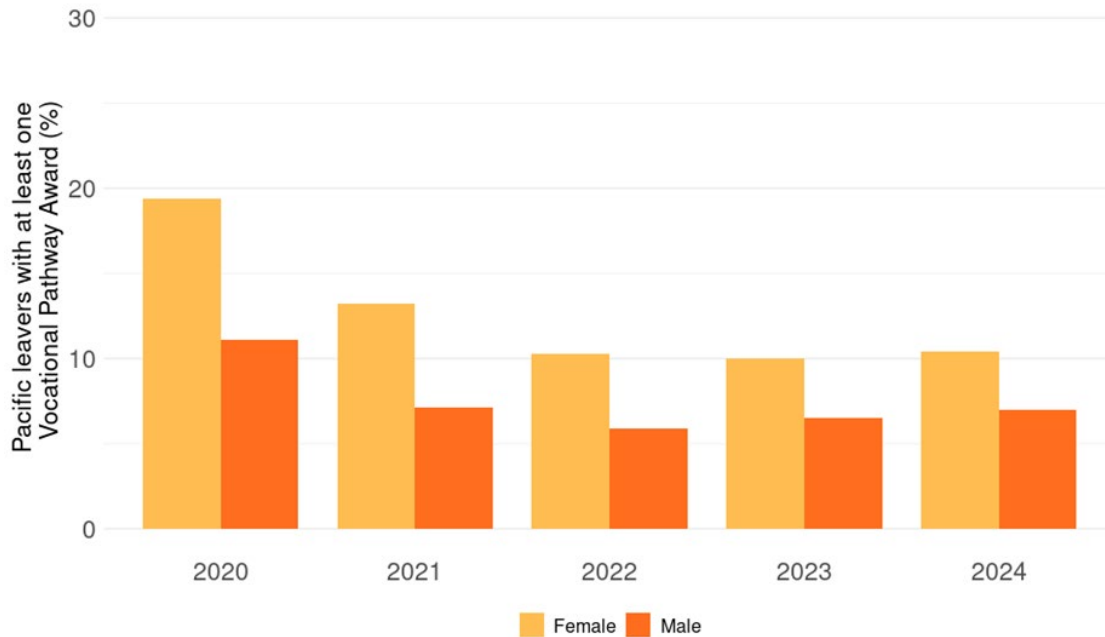
**Figure 10: Pacific school leavers attainment of NCEA Level 2 with any Vocational Pathways Award was higher in 2024 than in 2023**



In 2024, 10.5% of Pacific female school leavers attained NCEA Level 2 with any Vocational Pathways Award compared to 7% of Pacific male school leavers.

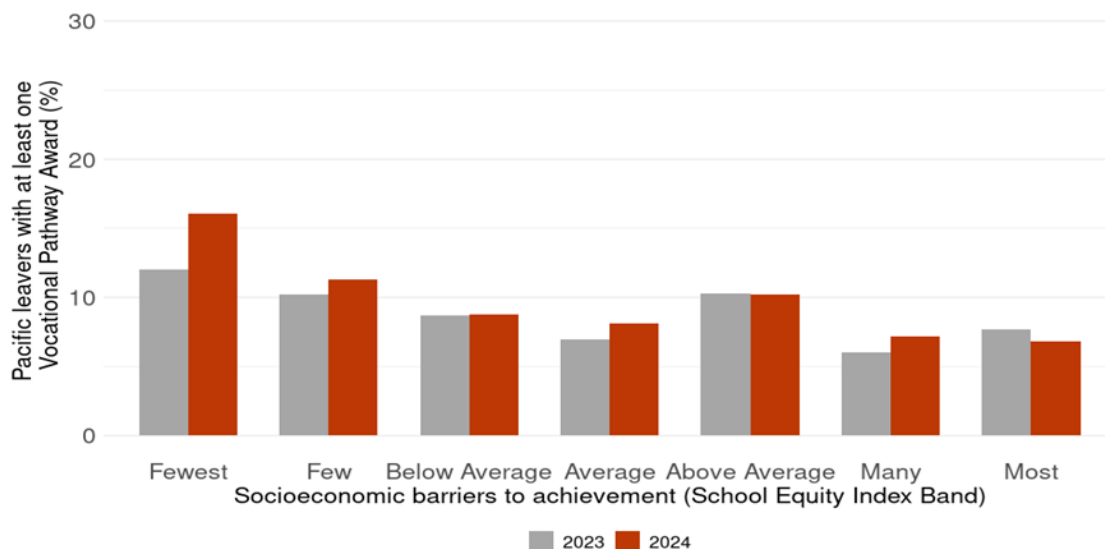


**Figure 11: The gap in attainment between female and male Pacific school leavers with NCEA Level 2 with any Vocational Pathways Award is decreasing**



Pacific school leavers from schools where students had fewer barriers to achievement were more likely to attain NCEA Level 2 with any Vocational Pathways Award. In 2024, 16.1% of Pacific leavers from schools where students had the fewest barriers to achievement attained NCEA Level 2 with any Vocational Pathways Award compared to 6.8% of Pacific leavers from schools where students had the most barriers to achievement. Attainment rates increased by 4.1 percentage points from 12% in 2023 to 16.1% in 2024 in schools where students had the fewest barriers to achievement. In schools where students had the most barriers to achievement, the attainment of Vocational Pathways Awards decreased from 7.7% in 2023 to 6.8% in 2024.

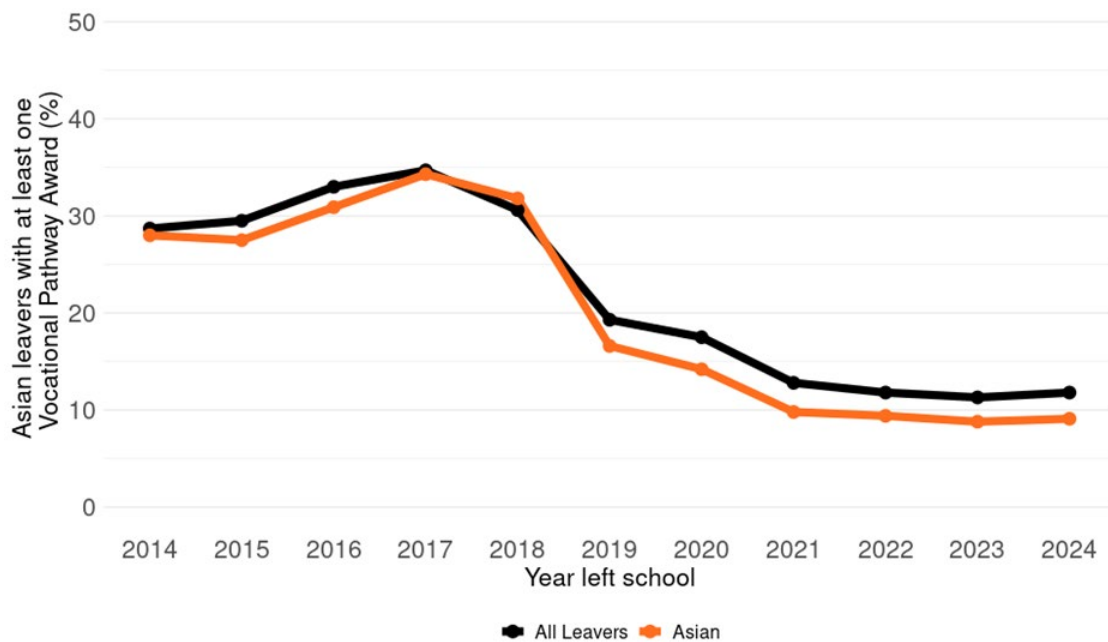
**Figure 12: Pacific school leavers' attainment of NCEA Level 2 with any Vocational Pathways Award for 2023 and 2024**



## Asian school leavers

In 2024, 989 Asian school leavers (9.1%) attained NCEA Level 2 with any Vocational Pathways Award, as shown in Figure 13. This was 0.3 percentage points up from 2023. Between 2017 (peak attainment for Asian learners) and 2024, the attainment of any Vocational Pathways Award decreased by 25.2 percentage points. Between 2020 (the first year of Covid-19) and 2024, the attainment rate decreased by 5.1 percentage points. The gap in the attainment of any Vocational Pathways Award between Asian school leavers and all school leavers in 2024 was 2.7 percentage points, up from 2.5 percentage points in 2023.

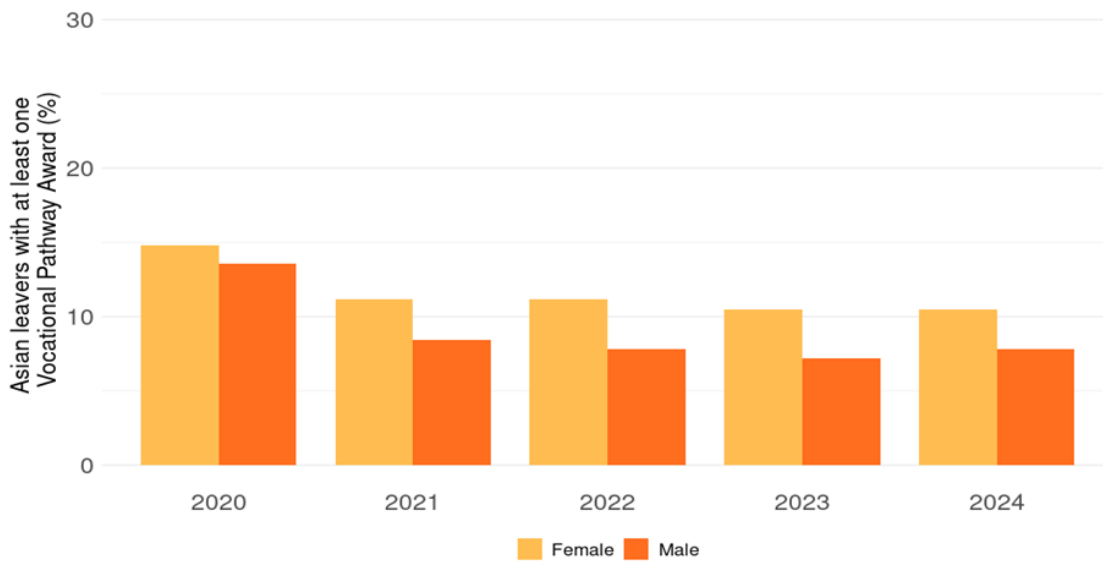
**Figure 13: Asian school leavers who attained NCEA Level 2 or above with at least one Vocational Pathways Awards increased in 2024**



In 2024, 10.5% of Asian female school leavers attained NCEA Level 2 with any Vocational Pathways Award compared to 7.8% of Asian male school leavers.

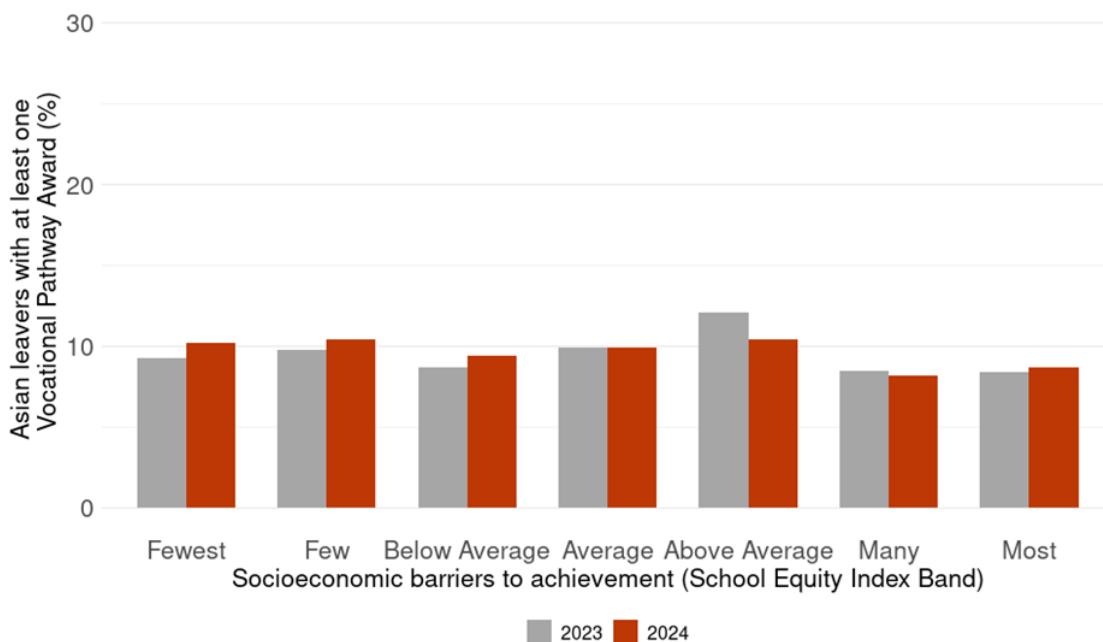


**Figure 14: Asian female school leavers were more likely to attain NCEA Level 2 with any Vocational Pathways Award**



The gradient effect for students in schools where students had fewer barriers to achievement was less evident for Asian school leavers. In 2024, the proportion of Asian school leavers from schools where students had the fewest barriers to achievement who attained NCEA Level 2 with any Vocational Pathways Award was 10.2% compared to 8.7% of Asian school leavers from schools where students had the most barriers to achievement.

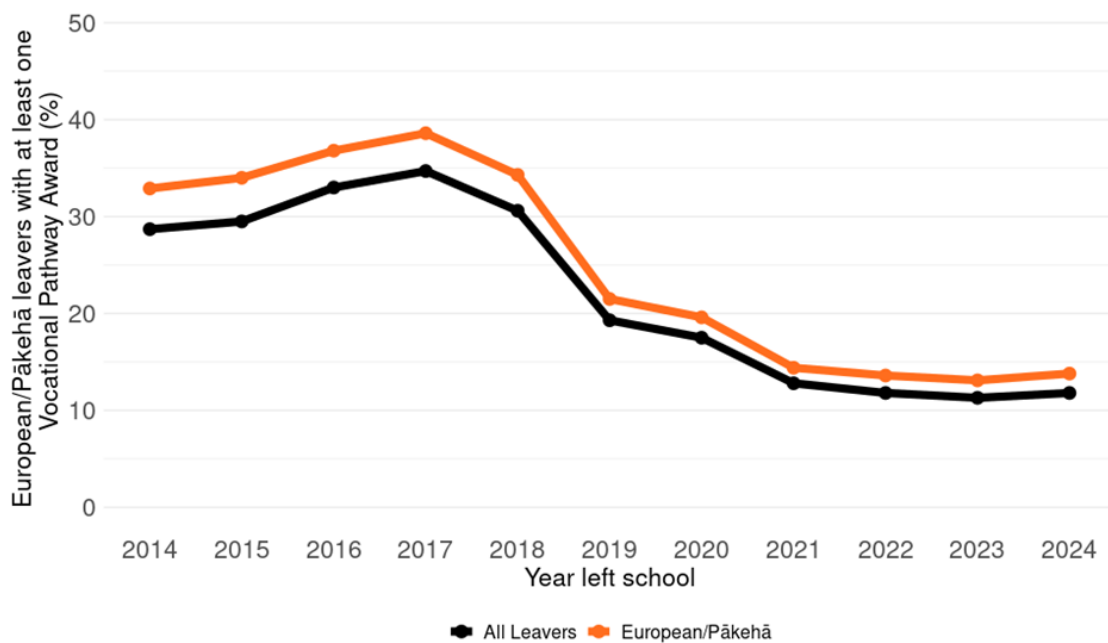
**Figure 15: The proportion of Asian school leavers with NCEA Level 2 with any Vocational Pathways Award remained stable in 2024**



## European/Pākehā school leavers

In 2024, 5,796 European/Pākehā school leavers (13.8%) attained NCEA Level 2 with any Vocational Pathways Award, as shown in Figure 16. This was 0.7 percentage points up from 2023. Between 2017 (peak attainment European/Pākehā) and 2024, the attainment of any Vocational Pathways Award decreased by 24.8 percentage points. Between 2020 (the first year of Covid-19) and 2024, the attainment rate decreased by 5.8 percentage points. The gap in the attainment of any Vocational Pathways Award between European/Pākehā school leavers and all school leavers in 2024 was 2 percentage points, up from 1.8 percentage points in 2023.

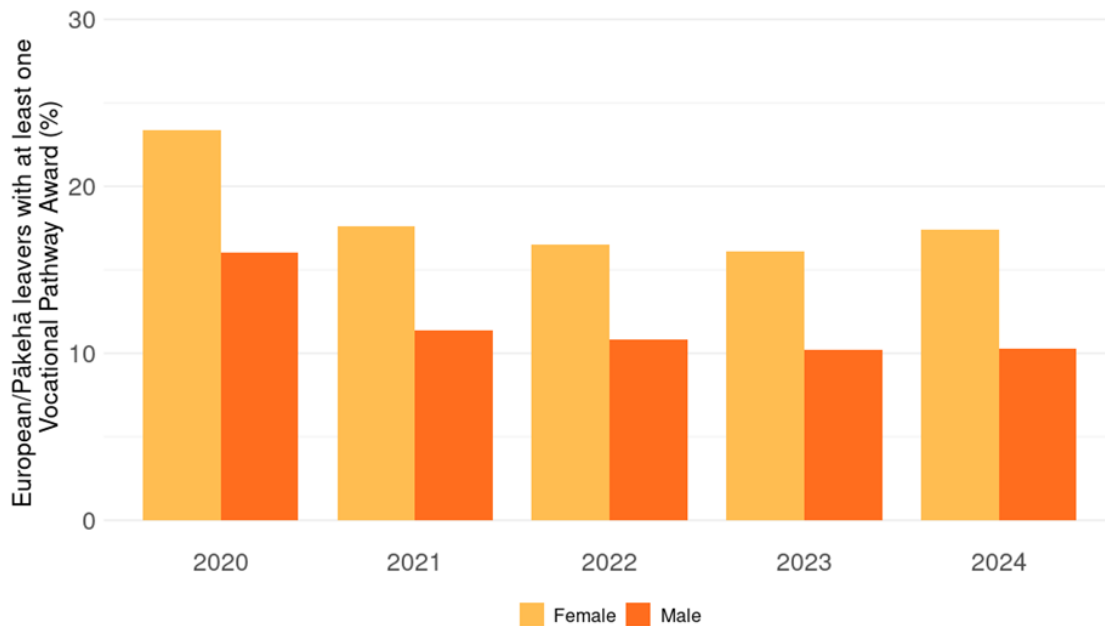
**Figure 16: European/Pākehā school leavers attainment of NCEA Level 2 with any Vocational Pathways Award**



In 2024, 17.4% of European/Pākehā female school leavers attained NCEA Level 2 with any Vocational Pathways Award compared to 10.3% of European/Pākehā male school leavers.

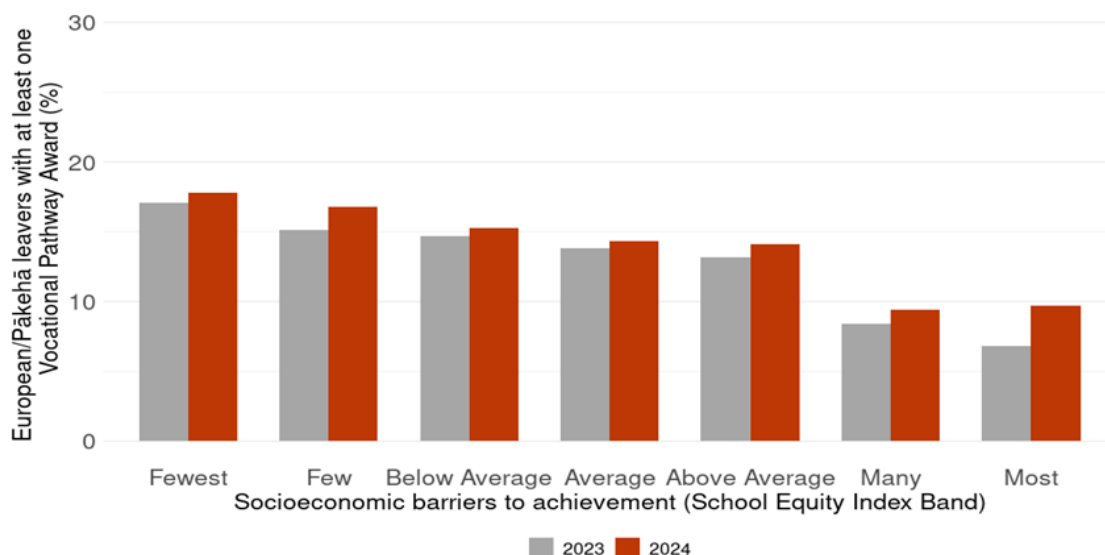


**Figure 17: The gender gap for European/Pākehā school leavers with NCEA Level 2 with any Vocational Pathways Award increased in 2024**



A higher proportion of European/Pākehā school leavers from schools where students had fewer barriers to achievement attained NCEA Level 2 with any Vocational Pathways Award. In 2024, 17.8% of European/Pākehā from schools where students had the fewest barriers to achievement attained NCEA Level 2 with any Vocational Pathways Award compared to 9.7% of European/Pākehā from schools where students had the most barriers to achievement.

**Figure 18: The proportion of European/Pākehā school leavers with NCEA Level 2 with any Vocational Pathways Award increased in 2024 compared to 2023**



## About equity index reporting

The Ministry has developed a new method of reporting on socioeconomic trends in education statistics called School Equity Index Bands and Groups. These categories estimate the extent to which, on average, students at a school face socioeconomic barriers that could get in the way of their school achievement. There are seven School Equity Index Bands, each containing approximately the same number of schools. Schools are placed into a band based on their Equity Index number. There are three School Equity Index Groups formed by collapsing the seven School Equity Index Bands as indicated in the following diagram. More information on this reporting method can be found on the Ministry's [Education Counts website](#).

### Schooling Equity Index Number:



### School Equity Index Band:

|        |     |               |         |               |      |      |
|--------|-----|---------------|---------|---------------|------|------|
|        |     |               |         |               |      |      |
| Fewest | Few | Below Average | Average | Above Average | Many | Most |

Socioeconomic barriers to achievement

### School Equity Index Group:

|       |          |      |
|-------|----------|------|
|       |          |      |
| Fewer | Moderate | More |

Socioeconomic barriers to achievement

## Where to find out more

To obtain more information about student attainment see:

- [Tracked Year 11 cohort – Attainment timeframes for Level 2 certificate](#)
- [School leaver pathways](#)
- [School leavers attainment](#)

## References

OCED. (2022). [Education at a glance 2022: OECD indicators](#) OECD Publishing.

